

URBAN DECENTRALIZATION AND THE DOMESTIC LANDSCAPE

I enjoy this suburban country beyond expression.

—FREDERICK LAW OLNSTED

Neither the competition for the design of Central Park nor the debate over appropriate gateways resolved the question of what an urban public park should be. Nor did the execution of other major public landscapes in the nineteenth century. To be sure, almost everyone agreed that parks, in some form, were necessary palliatives or correctives to the evils of the city; but there agreement ended. Others, especially Olmsted, regarded the park as complete in itself, a consciously contrived "natural" landscape that would have an "unconscious influence" on the visitor.

In retrospect Olmsted's vision that the park could be an oasis of rural beauty within but free from the intrusions of the urban environment seems, to some critics, a hopelessly naive legacy of the Victorian era. Indeed, over the last century Central Park and its progeny have been altered—perhaps irrevocably—to accommodate changing uses of park space and the evolution of modern recreation. As a result of the expansion of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the transformation of pastoral meadows into athletic fields, and the placement of statues, skating rinks, carousels, and playgrounds in the formerly naturalistic landscape, New York's park is fundamentally different from that conceived by the designers whom Richard Morris Hunt long ago castigated as "dreamers." Nevertheless, Central Park is, in the assessment of historian Carl Condit, "perhaps the greatest civic achievement of the United States in the nineteenth century." More broadly, the parks, parkways, and park systems it inspired are undoubtedly also that century's greatest contribution to city planning in America.¹

But Olmsted and Vaux admitted the park's limitations in refining and civilizing the urban environment. Even while directing initial improvements on Central Park they found wanting its relationship to

the city; but because of taste, politics, or financial considerations the Central Park commissioners ignored their arguments for, among other things, a better system of transportation to the park. As their 1866 and 1868 reports to the commissioners of Brooklyn's Prospect Park demonstrate, however, when given a more sympathetic audience Olmsted and Vaux presented the park as an integral part of a radically new arrangement of urban space. The system of parks and parkways they proposed for Brooklyn, like the boulevards Baron Haussmann was then constructing in Paris, was an attempt to create a more openly built city, to redefine urban form by incorporating large expanses of rural beauty that might help correct the congestion of the city and serve as institutions of social reform. But while Haussmann labored to provide an imperial setting for Napoleon III and to facilitate the rapid movement of troops, Olmsted and Vaux platted large new areas within the city as appropriate locations for middle-class homes. Parks, parkways, and openly built residential neighborhoods, they believed, would make obsolete the traditional criticism of the city as the locus of congestion, corruption, filth, and disease.²

What finally made possible the realization of Olmsted and Vaux's conception of the modern metropolis was the development of new forms of transportation that effectively shattered the limits of the walking city and reversed traditional patterns of land use. In the preindustrial city the wealthy usually lived in the center of town and the poor on the periphery, but an increase in "urban nuisances" during the nineteenth century rendered once fashionable neighborhoods less and less desirable. New transportation systems—at first omnibuses and ferries, later horse-drawn streetcars, steamboats, and locomotives—literally turned the city inside out, making possible the separation of residential and commercial neighborhoods, enabling the rich to move to homes in the suburbs, while the poor huddled in increasingly congested downtown areas. The resulting change in the physical geography of cities was dramatic. Historian Kenneth T. Jackson has identified a clear pattern of urban decentralization in northeastern cities as early as 1830, and throughout the remainder of the nineteenth century New York's suburbs "actually maintained a higher rate of growth than that of neighboring Manhattan."³

The process of urban decentralization began inconspicuously enough: at first people just moved farther and farther from their places of work. A Bostonian observed in 1838, "A number of our merchants have found that it is not absolutely necessary that their dwellings should be within five minutes' walk of their counting houses. Nay, they have even discovered that a daily walk from a cottage in an adjacent town is not a very frightful task." Though such a walk hardly would have struck terror into the hearts of most working-class men, few evidently found the rewards of a suburban home within their

means. A number of historians and urban geographers have demonstrated convincingly that during the antebellum years most laborers lived within a mile of their places of work, which likewise were clustered near similar establishments inside the city, because of considerations of time and the instability of job tenure. Moreover, most resided in rented quarters because the cost of purchasing or building a home on the periphery usually was prohibitive.⁴

Thus, at first only those people who owned carriages could afford the luxury of living beyond the limits of the walking city. Manhattan's fabled march uptown was led by the wealthy and fashionable, who relocated in less congested and more attractive neighborhoods. In Philadelphia it was also the rich who moved to outlying areas. Sidney George Fisher identified a rapidly increasing "taste for country life" among his genteel peers. "New and tasteful homes are built every year," he observed in 1847, especially in Germantown, which was desirable for being "perfectly healthy & the scenery very handsome."⁵

If at first it was predominantly the wealthy who enjoyed the opportunity to escape crowded urban areas, mass transportation systems made possible the development of middle-class residential neighborhoods some distance from centers of business and from tenement districts. For those who could pay the fares—usually five or six cents, which was too expensive for the poor—the street omnibuses that became widely used in the 1830s and 1840s effectively enlarged the limits of the city. The *Baltimore Sun* praised the omnibus for enabling "persons to reside at a distance from their places of business in more healthy locations without loss of time and fatigue in walking." The impact of even so rudimentary a transportation innovation as the omnibus was galvanic. Sir Charles Lyell discovered in 1846 that during a five-month absence from New York "whole streets had been built, and several squares finished in the northern or fashionable end of town, to which the merchants are now resorting, leaving the business end, near the Battery, where they formerly lived."⁶

More significant as a cause of decentralization were the horse-drawn street railways that came to dominate urban transportation networks in the 1850s. These streetcars were much larger than omnibuses and carried a greater number of people. By riding on rails they afforded a more comfortable trip than was possible on cobbled or unpaved city streets, and their greater speed enabled people to live in homes even farther from the center of town. On a drive through Germantown in August of 1857, Fisher reported that what was once a village had been transformed into an attractive suburb, "adorned with elegance & supplied with all the conveniences of a city—shops, gas, water-works, with none of the annoyances of town, but quiet, country scenery and trees everywhere." Two years later he astutely ascribed

the growth of Philadelphia's numerous suburbs to the "horse railroads," which enabled "anyone to enjoy the pleasures of country life and at the same time attend business in town." According to Fisher, by making possible the development of residential neighborhoods on the urban periphery, the streetcar brought about a decisive change in the arrangement of cities. The advantages of suburbs, he wrote,

are so obvious that this villa & cottage life has become quite a passion and is producing a complete revolution in our habits. It is dispersing the people of the city over the surrounding country, introducing thus among them, ventilation, cleanliness, space, healthful pursuits, and the influences of natural beauty, the want of which are the sources of so much evil, moral & physical, in large towns.

Because streetcars had rendered suburban homes so convenient, Fisher wondered "how any can bear to stay in town."⁷

The development of commuter railways extended still further the possibilities of suburban growth. Lewis Mumford has argued persuasively that the railroad served as a centralizing device by causing the concentration of population and industry in urban areas. But as much as it contributed to the dominance of central cities, the railroad also telescoped distances, bringing country and city closer together. Emerson praised this new improvement in transportation for the "increased acquaintance it has given the American people with the boundless resources of their own soil." To him the railroad was less noteworthy for its centralizing tendencies than for its ability to bring Easterners into contact with the "tranquilizing, sanative influences" of nature. H. W. S. Cleveland also noted the duality of the railroad's impact. In 1855 he observed, "Every railroad becomes a salient point of the city, and the busy mart, which heretofore has been so called, is now but the heart of this widely extended metropolis."⁸

Thus, while it caused concentration of activity, the railroad also resulted in urban decentralization and the separation of commercial and residential neighborhoods. Andrew Jackson Downing, who castigated the practice of building cities "as though there was a frightful scarcity of space," recognized the potential of this new form of transportation. He reasoned that, although they were originally built for commerce, railroads "cannot wholly escape doing some duty for the Beautiful, as well as the Useful," by opening land for nonurban development. In his estimation, travel by train "half annihilated" old notions of time and space and enabled thousands of city workers to reside in a "country cottage, several miles distant." This surely was the case in Boston, where the railroad was at first the primary means of transportation to outlying areas: by 1850 there were eighty-three commuter stations within a fifteen-mile radius of the city, some with as many as thirty-two trains per day carrying passengers to and from Boston.⁹

What might be termed the "urban transportation revolution" dramatically altered the spatial arrangement of cities. Following the paths of the streetcar lines, Bostonians moved to Roxbury and Dorchester, Philadelphians to Germantown, and New Yorkers to northern Manhattan. Regularly scheduled ferry service rendered Brooklyn and New Jersey attractive residential options. Fredrika Bremer observed that some of New York's merchants had chosen to "have their house and home" in Brooklyn. Walt Whitman's "Crossing Brooklyn Ferry" paid poetic tribute to the "hundreds and hundreds that cross, returning home." Others moved to Jersey in order to "enjoy those solid comforts which can only be obtained away from the tainted atmosphere of a city life." The English visitor Lady Emmeline Stuart Wortley learned that in New York, "incessant communication is kept up between the city and its picturesque, prosperous, and rapidly increasing suburbs, by means of steam ferry-boats, the Harlem Railroad, and omnibuses." So great were the pace and extent of decentralization, in New York and in virtually every other city, that by 1870 Cincinnati journalist Sidney Denise Maxwell could describe urban growth as a new form of imperialism: "In all directions the city is moving on to conquest, the flower of her population deployed as skirmishers, who steadily advance upon a country that little thinks or knows what powers of expansion and absorption belong to the cities of this country."¹⁰

Unfortunately, in most cities the "conquest" of surrounding country took the form of extending over it the old urban landscape, the icon of commercial rather than domestic values, the gridiron. The relentless, unplanned expansion of urban rectilinearity led the editor of the *Crayon* to lament the absence of walls surrounding America's cities: "There is something in a wall which divides the city from the country, and while it shuts man into the former, by a kind of stimulant to contrariness drives him out into the latter. Here city grows into country; we never know when we leave one or enter into the other." As the process of decentralization inevitably increased the value of property on the periphery, real estate promoters and railroad and streetcar companies purchased distant tracts, laid out rectangular streets, and sold house lots in what they described as ideal suburban communities. Too often these developments were the work of speculators in search of a fast profit or of companies unwilling or unable to defer return on the cost of buying and improving the land, and the results were regrettable. Although they promised buyers a combination of rural pleasures and ease of access to the city, such suburbs sacrificed the advantages of urban life.¹¹

The development of the village of Dearman (now Irvington), New York, demonstrates the least appealing aspects of suburban speculation. A large, hilly tract overlooking the Hudson, Dearman was located in Westchester County, twenty miles north of New York City,

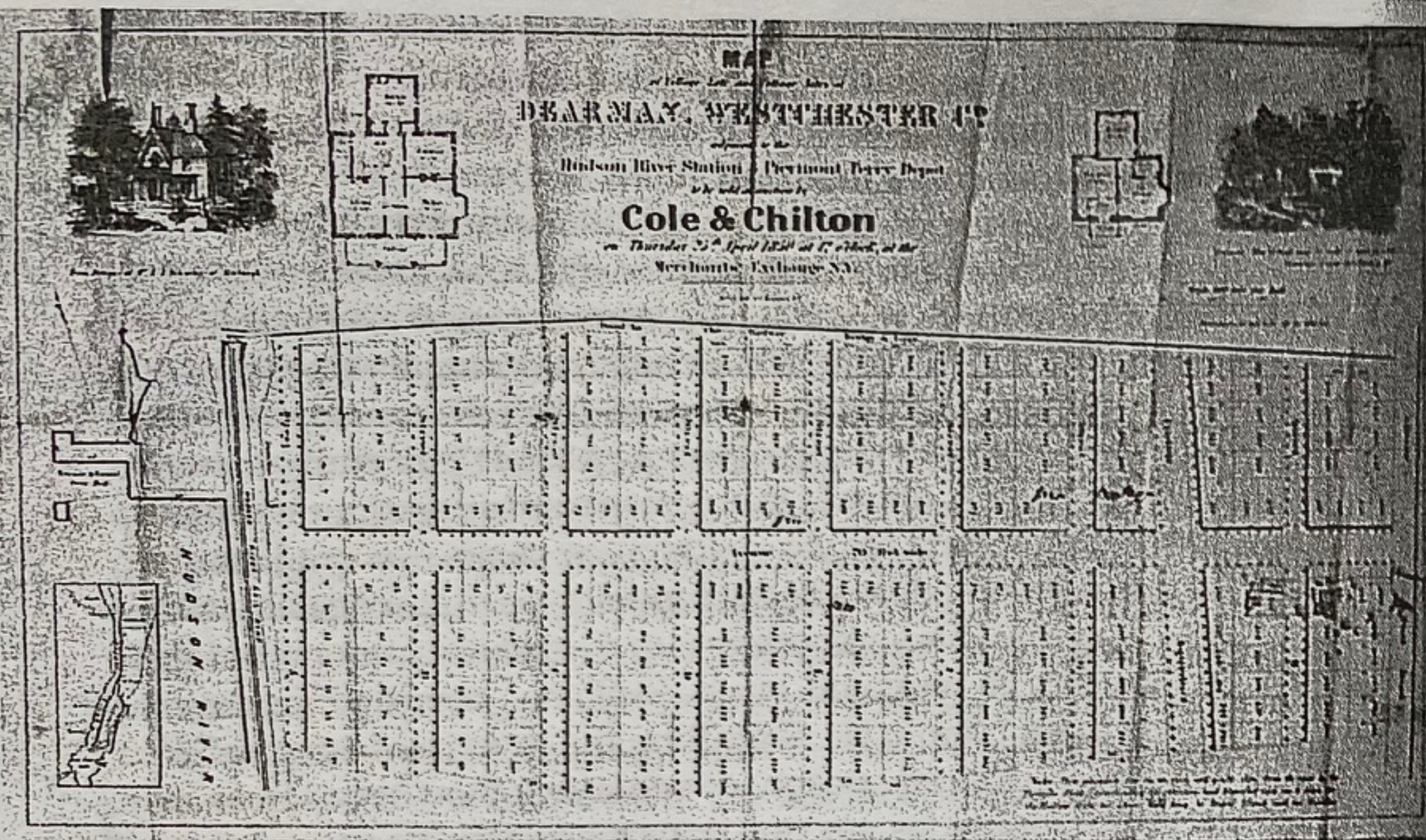


Figure 29. Plan of Dearman (now Irvington), Westchester County, New York, 1851, Cole and Chilton, Promoters. (Courtesy, Collection of the Hudson River Museum, Yonkers, New York.)

and was connected to the metropolis by the Hudson River Railroad, the Albany Post Road, and frequent steamboat excursions. The site possessed all the requisites for advantageous development in what Downing called the "modern" or "natural" style of landscape gardening. Such a plan, with curvilinear streets and irregularly shaped lots following the contour of the land, would not only have enhanced the site's attractiveness but would have reduced the cost of grading and filling the property. Dearman's promoters, Cole and Chilton, instead imposed on the hilly topography the rectangular grid (fig. 29). The speculative intent was obvious: from the time John Randel laid out Manhattan's street system, every fast-growing city had learned of the gridiron's advantages for "buying, selling, and improving real estate." Following this precedent, Cole and Chilton planned a central avenue, seventy feet wide, running east from the river (directly up a hill), and eight narrower intersecting streets running parallel to the Hudson. Throughout the tract they placed uniform lots of fifty by one hundred feet.¹²

Downing had special cause for concern over the Dearman plan. Although the developmental scheme violated every precept of landscape theory he had promulgated in the preceding decade, Cole and Chilton nevertheless attempted to capitalize on his enormous popularity by placing engravings from Downing's *Cottage Residences* (1842) in the upper left and right corners of their plan. Downing

must have been enraged and, with this misrepresentation as incentive, offered a devastating critique of the speculative village. His response, the essay "Our Country Villages," proceeded to outline a theoretical plan that codified the suburban ideal in nineteenth-century America.¹³

Because of the rapid development of cities and territories throughout the United States, Downing reasoned that "the plan and arrangement of new towns ought to be a matter of national importance." He was particularly distressed by the development of recently platted suburbs along the Hudson, which claimed to combine "the advantages of the country with easy railroad access" to the city. In a veiled reference to Dearman, Downing wrote that fifty-foot lots and rows of houses along shaded streets composed "the sum total of the rural beauty, convenience and comfort of the latest plan for a rural village in the Union." In forsaking the city the purchaser acquired only "his little patch of back and front yard, [and] a little peep down the street, looking one way at the river, and the other way at the sky." A resident sacrificed the urban amenities, yet found himself in a place with "houses on all sides, almost as closely placed as in the city, which he has endeavored to fly from."¹⁴

Other arbiters of taste echoed Downing's criticism of the gridiron suburb. From the "Editor's Easy Chair" at *Harper's*, George William Curtis excoriated the "taste which would carve up such a town site as Dearman or Abbotsford, upon the steep slope of a river bank, into rectangular squares." He asserted that "roads in country villages ought to wind," because such streets were cheaper to build and increased the number of scenic views. Similarly did the authors of *Village and Farm Cottages* scorn the speculator who laid out a suburban community with the "checker-board exactness" of a city. Even worse was the builder of "city tenements" in the country, the villain who "covers the ground with narrow cells, and advertises to sell or rent them as charming rural residences." H. W. S. Cleveland lamented the "experiments of speculators, who lay out rectangular villages with the aid of a surveyor, and offer rural felicity for sale in lots of thirty by fifty feet." John Jay Smith was also among the critics of promoters whose desire for profits justified the application of a rectangular grid to the urban periphery.¹⁵

Significantly, each of these commentators thought of the gridiron as urban form and considered its use in suburban development especially reprehensible. If a suburb were to be a place where families escaped the "turmoil of cities," Downing reasoned, it must take on aspects of the country. Thus, in "Our Country Villages" he asserted that a suburban community must be more than "mere rows of houses upon streets crossing each other at right angles, and bordered with shade trees." Admitting that "people must live in towns and villages,"

he charged his readers with the task of improving them. The most important desideratum of a community, Downing believed, was a large, centrally located "open space, common, or park." This area, jointly owned by all lot holders, "would be the nucleus or *heart of the village*, and would give it an essentially rural character." Downing recommended that the largest and finest residences front the park and that, by the "imperative arrangement" of other streets and houses, the village proprietors secure "sufficient space, view, circulation of air, and broad, well-planted avenues of shade trees." John Jay Smith also insisted that suburban developers include in their plans space for a "healthful promenade," and instead of a rectangular grid he suggested the treatment of the entire town as a residential park.¹⁶

To Downing and to other spokesmen who articulated the suburban ideal at mid-century, the suburb was more than a speculative subdivision: it was a community that, by conscious design and allocation of public and private spaces, attempted to reconcile the family's desire for a home amid natural surroundings with the trenchant realities of urban growth and change. A house in such a suburb enabled a family to escape the congestion, disease, and "immoral influences" of the city and to rear children in more beneficial surroundings, while retaining ease of access to urban jobs and to the social and cultural attractions of the metropolis.¹⁷

One of the most extraordinary of nineteenth-century planned suburban communities was Evergreen Hamlet (fig. 30), established in 1851 on an eighty-five-acre site at Millvale, Pennsylvania, near Pittsburgh. William M. Shinn, promoter and first trustee, joined with five other friends to form the nucleus of what they anticipated would become a sixteen-family village. In a remarkable real estate prospectus, Shinn announced that the purpose of the hamlet was to secure "the advantages and comforts of the country, at moderate cost, without doing violence to the social habits incident to city life." Such a community would unite "some of the benefits of country and city" and "avoid some of the inconveniences and disadvantages of both." To this end Shinn organized Evergreen Hamlet as a joint-stock corporation committed to communitarian principles. Excepting the sixteen house lots, all land was held in common. Families shared the cost of maintaining a schoolhouse (where children were trained "under a system approximating to 'Home Education'"), an icehouse, a farm building, and other facilities. Only six families constructed dwellings at Evergreen Hamlet, however, and after Shinn's death in 1865 the town dissolved its joint-stock status.¹⁸

One of the first and undoubtedly the most influential early suburb established according to Downing's precepts was Llewellyn Park, New Jersey, located twelve miles west of New York City on the eastern

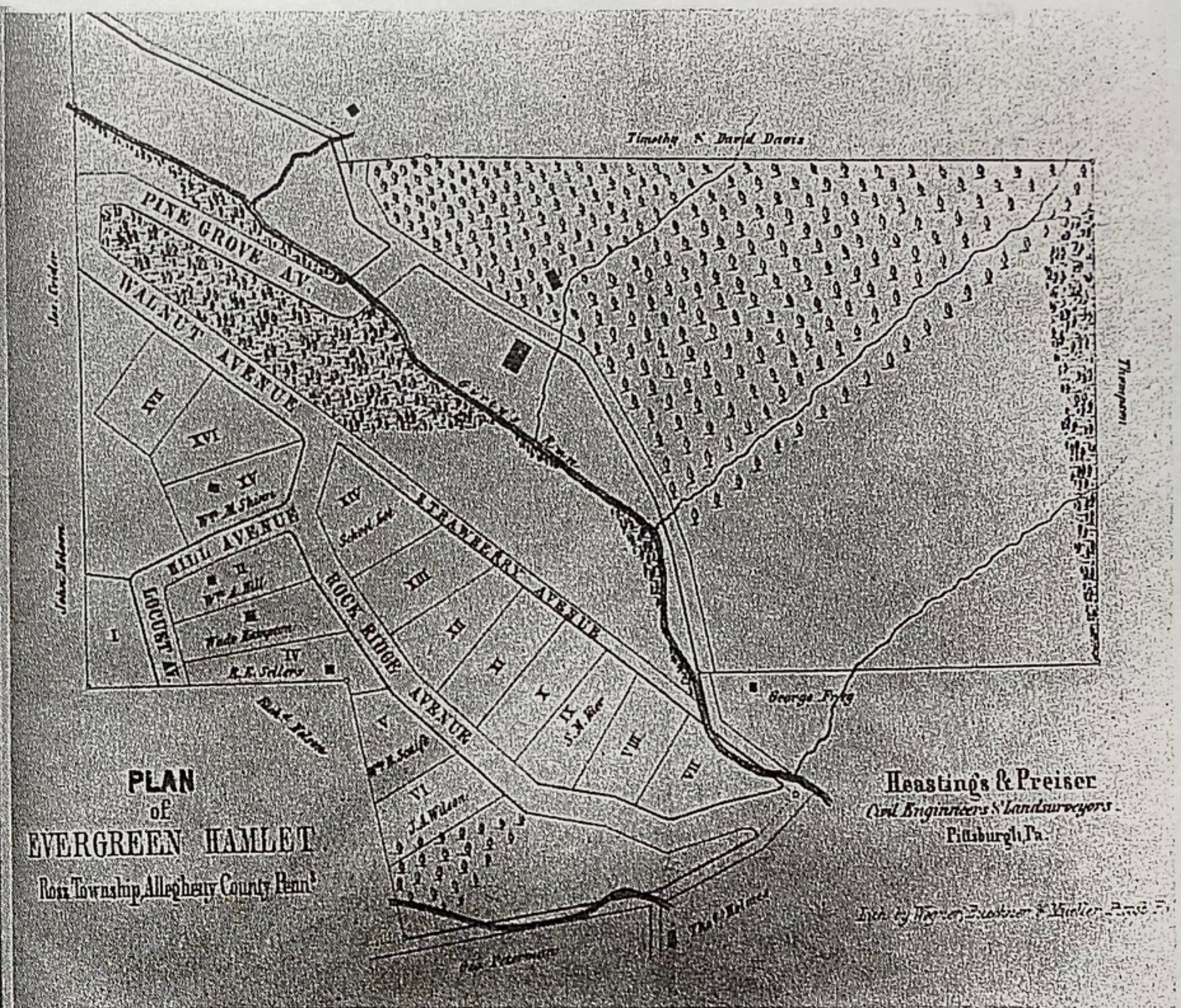


Figure 30. Plan of Evergreen Hamlet, Allegheny County, Pennsylvania, 1851, William Shinn, Trustee. From *Constitution of Evergreen Hamlet* (Pittsburgh, 1851). (Courtesy, Historical Society of Western Pennsylvania, Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania.)

slope of Orange Mountain. According to a real estate prospectus, the site combined "healthfulness of climate," beauty of situation, and "ease of access" to the metropolis. Intended as the location of "country homes for city people," Llewellyn Park was planned "with special reference to the wants of citizens doing business in the city of New York, and yet wishing accessible, retired, and healthful homes in the country." Those families who relocated in Llewellyn Park also retained most of the amenities of the city: although the site was "fairly in the country" the proximity of the town of Orange ensured that residents could "secure the necessities of life with the greatest possible convenience."¹⁹

This residential park was the creation of Llewellyn S. Haskell, a New York drug importer, who occasionally was assisted by the architect Alexander Jackson Davis. In 1853 failing health led Haskell

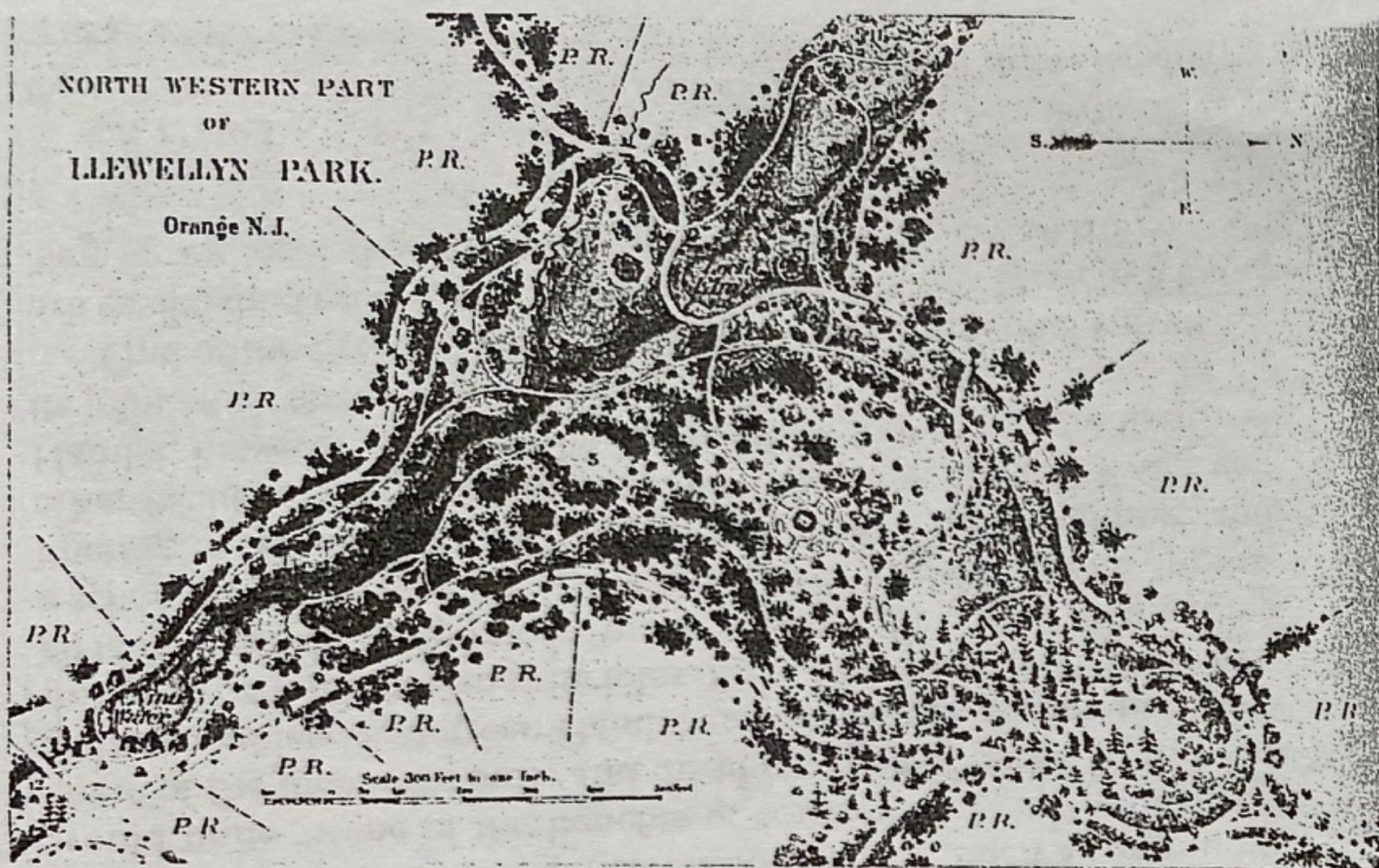


Figure 31. Plan of Llewellyn Park, New Jersey, 1853, showing park with space for private residences arranged around it. From A. J. Downing, *A Treatise on the Theory and Practice of Landscape Gardening, Adapted to North America...* (1841; New York, 1875). (Courtesy, The Henry Francis duPont Winterthur Museum Library, Collection of Printed Books, Winterthur, Delaware.)

to purchase as the site for his home a property known as Eagle Rock, a forty-acre tract on Orange Mountain, which was noted for its stunning scenery and reputed to be particularly healthful. Soon after building his own residence Haskell, perhaps at Davis's suggestion, conceived the idea of organizing a suburban community and began acquiring adjacent farms. By 1857 he had amassed 350 acres of "well-wooded and beautifully broken and diversified" land; thirteen years later Llewellyn Park embraced almost 750 acres. Together with Davis and landscape gardeners Eugene A. Baumann and Howard Daniels, Haskell began to shape what he considered the ideal residential village.²⁰

Like Downing, Haskell considered a park essential to the success of a suburban community, and in 1857 he donated to the newly organized village trustees a centrally located park of fifty acres (fig. 31). This area, known as the "Ramble," was jointly owned by all lot proprietors, who paid an annual assessment (not to exceed ten dollars per acre) for maintenance of the park and of the roads and walks of the village. Extending almost a mile in length, the park included a "finely wooded ravine" and a brook, which was dammed to form artificial ponds. A circuit drive girded the Ramble, and such ornamental structures as kiosks, summerhouses, rustic seats, and bridges embellished the in-

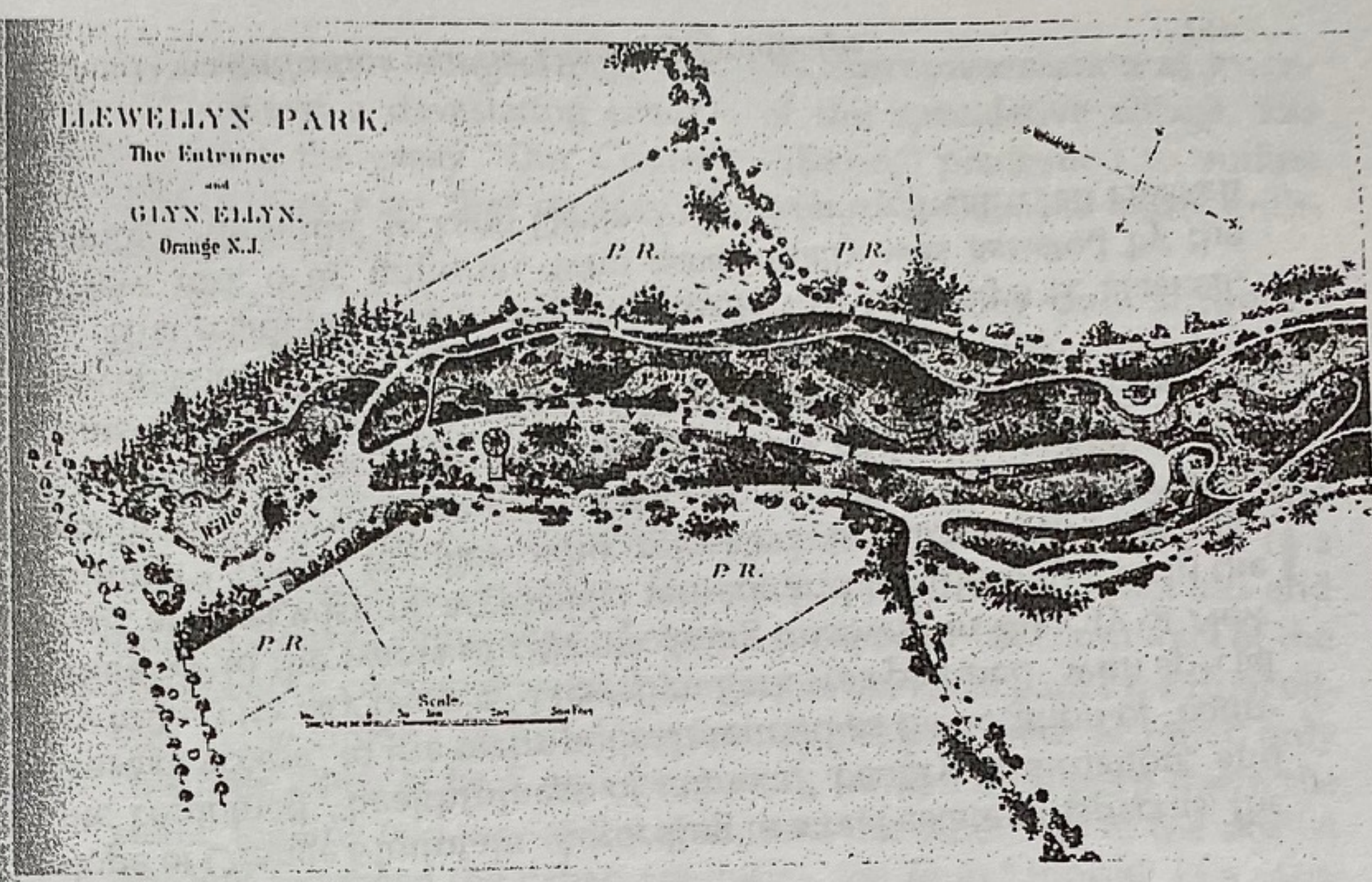


Figure 32. Llewellyn Park, the Glen. From A. J. Downing, *Treatise on the Theory and Practice of Landscape Gardening, Adapted to North America...* (1841; New York, 1875). (Courtesy, The Henry Francis duPont Winterthur Museum Library, Collection of Printed Books, Winterthur, Delaware.)

terior (fig. 32). One contemporary visitor noted that the park's "irregularity of form" afforded great "variety of surface and feeling of size" and furnished "secluded and quiet nooks and most pleasant surprises."²¹

Surrounding the Ramble, Haskell and his associates placed sites for suburban homes. Llewellyn Park was designed to accommodate one hundred families on lots varying in size from one to twenty acres, with a six-acre plot being the average holding. No fences separated individual properties, which contributed to "the appearance of a single very large landscaped estate." Throughout the village Haskell placed ten miles of gently curving roads and walks. The result, he asserted, was more than a community affording urban amenities amid rural surroundings, or handsome sites for suburban homes combined with ready access to the city. Because of the Ramble and the absence of fences demarcating property lines, Llewellyn Park enabled a "family occupying a small place in the country, costing only a few thousands of dollars, to enjoy all the advantages of an extensive country-seat, without the expense or trouble attending the latter."²²

At about the same time Haskell was acquiring the land for Llewellyn Park, Nathaniel Parker Willis suggested a plan (never implemented) for a suburban community, Highland Terrace, to be located on the west bank of the Hudson River between Cornwall and

Newburgh. For Willis, the completion of the Erie Railroad and frequent steamboat excursions on the Hudson made the river an extension of Broadway, enabling individuals and their families to live in rural surroundings fifty miles from New York while maintaining access to urban amusements, conveniences, and society. Echoing Downing and others, Willis envisioned Highland Terrace as a retreat for those "who have rural tastes and metropolitan refinements rationally blended—who have families which they wish to surround with the healthful and elegant belongings of a home, while, at the same time, they wish to keep pace with the world." Residence at Highland Terrace, he assured his readers, would be a "mixture of city and country, with the home in the country."²³

Similar in arrangement to Llewellyn Park and in conception to Downing's and Willis's suburban ideal was the village of Irving Park, established in 1859 as a one-hundred-acre residential community overlooking the Hudson at Tarrytown, New York. Repeating Haskell's earlier claims, Irving Park's promoter, Charles H. Lyon, praised the site as "entirely healthy and free from fever and ague." He pointed out that the location was especially desirable because of its "extensive views" of river scenery. Tarrytown was advantageous as a residential area, he announced, because "the distance from the city is entirely in its favor, being near enough for the requirements of business men, and yet far enough away to escape some well-known annoyances, and to realize all the retirement that constitutes the great charm of rural life." At his own expense Lyon constructed gateways, lodges, ornamental structures, and roads and offered for sale lots of from one to eight acres in extent (fig. 33). He reserved almost fifty acres of the property for a park "to be used in common by all the occupants." Thus at Irving Park a purchaser acquired a site for a home in the country, accessible to the city, as well as joint ownership of an extensive pleasure ground. A writer in *Harper's Weekly* praised the site as admirably "adapted to the purpose of a *Neighborhood Park*," one especially appropriate for the man who conducted his business in the city but who saw "no reason why he should establish his household in the same tumultuous arena." The editor of the *Horticulturist* predicted that this "system of united effort will become the custom when its advantages are more disseminated."²⁴

Dozens, perhaps hundreds of subdivisions or planned communities were begun in the 1850s, but outbreak of the Civil War retarded the realization of the suburban ideal. For antebellum generations, the ownership of land in cities and on their periphery was a safe and remunerative investment. As cities grew, even vacant land increased in value, bringing owners what Henry George later called "unearned increments" on their capital. Developing a suburban community, however, was a different kind of venture, requiring substantial initial

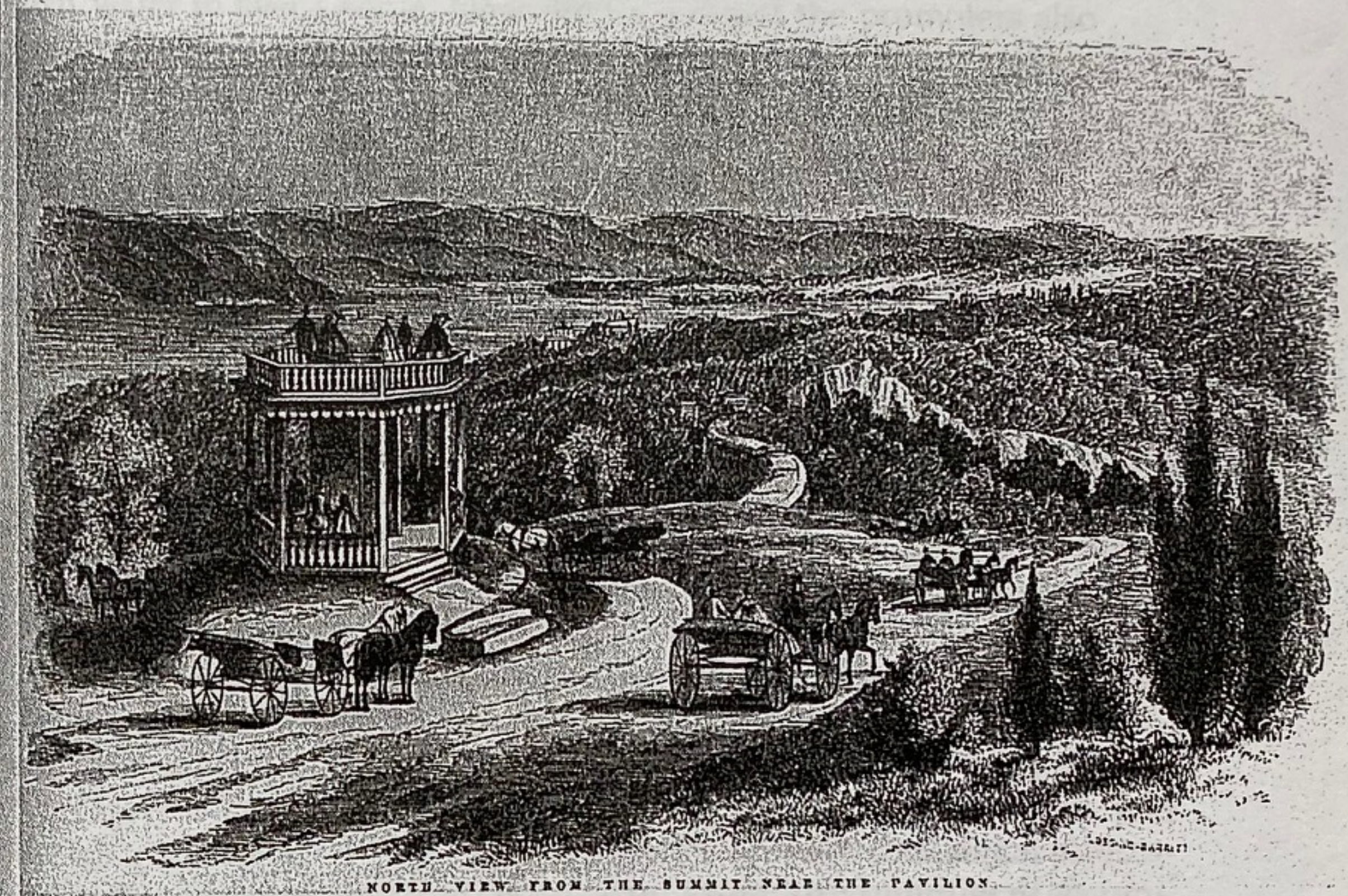


Figure 33. View of Irving Park, Tarrytown, New York, 1859. From *Description of Irving Park, Tarrytown; The Property of Charles H. Lyon* (New York, 1859). (Courtesy, Frances Loeb Library, Graduate School of Design, Harvard University, Cambridge, Massachusetts.)

expenditures for the purchase and preparation of land and the construction of roads, a park, and ancillary structures. Haskell, for example, is said to have spent as much as one hundred thousand dollars landscaping Llewellyn Park, and Charles Lyon's preliminary improvements at Irving Park demanded a "very considerable pecuniary outlay." These promoters expected to recoup expenses and eventually earn a profit through the sale of building lots which had been made more desirable by their efforts.²⁵

Wartime economy, however, disrupted such investment. Historian Allan Nevins reports the failure, in 1861, of almost six thousand Northern businesses holding liabilities of some 178.5 million dollars. Although by 1863 this financial instability was replaced by what Nevins calls the "great boom in the North," the war obviously had a decided impact on the national economy. State and local governments paid bounties to meet recruitment quotas, the federal government borrowed 830 million dollars through the sale of bonds, new levies on goods and income drained cash away from consumers, and inflation sent prices soaring. Moreover, wartime spending redirected the flow of capital formerly invested in land to industries providing

materials needed for the prosecution of the war—munitions factories and military suppliers, of course, but also oil producers and distributors, mechanization of agriculture, and countless new industries promising fabulous dividends. But although economic concentration in such enterprises intensified after the war, interest in the domestic environment and the creation of suburban communities revived with the return of peace.²⁶

Because of its comprehensive design and national influence the most important suburb developed in the immediate postbellum years was the community at Riverside, Illinois. Three years after Appomattox, Emery E. Childs invited the firm of Olmsted, Vaux & Company to submit a design for a suburb to be located on a sixteen-hundred-acre farm, formerly owned by David A. Gage, nine miles west of Chicago on the banks of the Des Plaines River. Included on the property would be the first suburban station of the Chicago, Burlington, and Quincy Railroad, which would provide convenient access to the city. After studying the environs for beauty of scenery and characteristics conducive to health, Olmsted and Vaux pronounced Riverside "the only available ground near Chicago which does not present disadvantages of an almost helpless character."²⁷

In their preliminary report to the Riverside Improvement Company, Olmsted and Vaux rejected the Llewellyn Park model of development, and in this they differed in significant ways from Downing and other early proponents of the suburban ideal. This change of approach took place over a short period of time: in 1865 Olmsted had informed Vaux that he was designing Berkeley Neighborhood "upon the Llewellyn plan," but within four years he had found the design of Haskell's residential park lacking, particularly in its proscribing of fences dividing properties. "I think that the want of fences, of distinct family separation," he informed Edward Everett Hale, "is the real cause of the ill-success or want of great success of Mr. Haskell's undertaking." Properly designed suburban homes required "*private outside apartments*," Olmsted asserted, and as a result he came to consider the fence "a sort of outer wall of the house."²⁸

Olmsted believed, then, that a suburban community should be more than a park divided into building lots. Although both the park and the suburb offered alternatives to the "constantly repeated right angles, sharp lines, and flat surfaces" of the city, he and Vaux asserted that the purposes of recreational grounds and residential neighborhoods were distinct. In their design for the Long Meadow at Prospect Park, for example, Olmsted and Vaux had created a sweeping greensward surrounded by trees and pools of water. The function of such a park space was to convey to the visitor a sensation of spaciousness, of rural tranquility not otherwise obtainable within the city. By contrast, they explained, the "essential qualification of a suburb is domesticity,"

the privacy of the family home in congenial surroundings. Handsome houses in well-designed suburbs, Olmsted and Vaux noted, exemplified the "most attractive, the most refined and the most soundly wholesome forms of domestic life, and the best application of the arts of civilization to which mankind has yet attained."²⁹

The improvements Olmsted and Vaux deemed necessary to make the Riverside tract conform to the suburban ideal would be expensive, and to argue their case more persuasively they placed community development within the context of urban growth. The "most prominent characteristic of the present period of civilization," they informed the Riverside promoters, "has been the strong tendency of people to flock together in great towns." According to Olmsted and Vaux the response to urban growth in the nineteenth century was twofold: first was the development of new concepts of city planning that promoted the separation of compact business districts and residential areas with "rural spaciousness"; second was a countermigration from city to suburb. The landscape architects astutely reminded Riverside's promoters that the growth of suburbs was part of the process of urbanization, a movement that sought "not a sacrifice of urban conveniences, but their combination with the special charms and substantial advantages of rural conditions of life." The qualities of a refined suburban environment thus marked "not a regression from, but an advance upon, those which are characteristic of town life."³⁰

Following this explication of the purposes of a suburb, Olmsted and Vaux addressed the question of Riverside's means of access to the city. To supplement the railroad they suggested construction of a broad pleasure drive, varying in width from two hundred to six hundred feet, planted with clumps of trees and made convenient by occasional shelters and watering places along the road. As they had proposed for the parkways in Brooklyn and other cities, Olmsted and Vaux again suggested separation of pedestrian, equestrian, carriage, and commercial traffic on Riverside's grand promenade. On pleasant days this drive would afford the businessman opportunity for "taking air and exercise" amid delightful surroundings on the journey to and from work. For the community the promenade would be a kind of umbilical cord, providing conveyance to the city and the "essential, intellectual, artistic, and social privileges which specially pertain to a metropolitan condition of society."³¹

Olmsted and Vaux then turned to the design of the suburb (fig. 34). The initial requirement of such a village, they noted, was the construction of "good roads and walks, pleasant to the eye within themselves, and having at intervals pleasant openings and outlooks, with suggestions of refined domestic life, secluded, but not far removed from the life of the community." Because in a suburb comfort was far more important than speed of travel, they recommended that

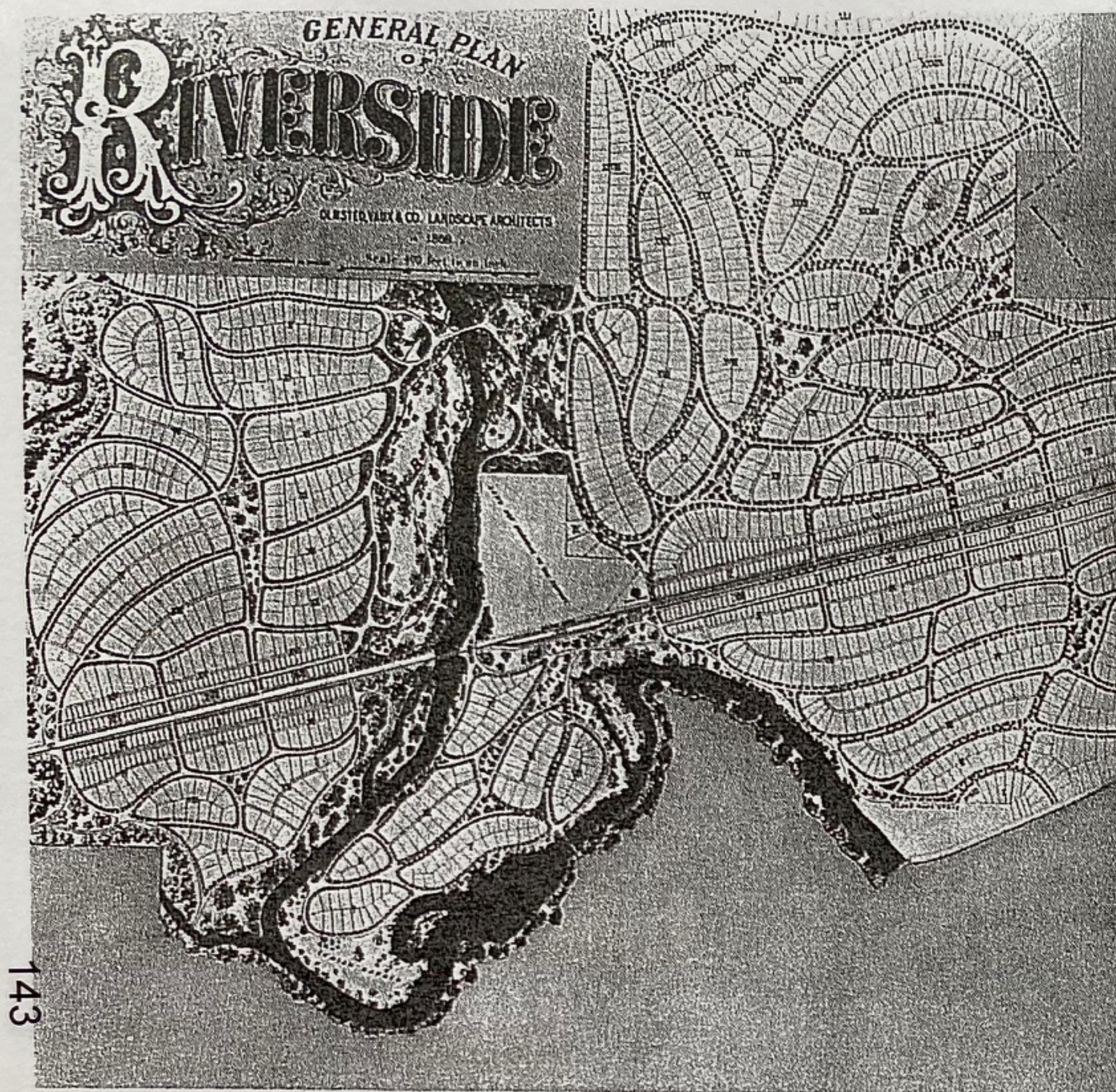


Figure 34. Plan of Riverside, Illinois, by Olmsted, Vaux & Company, 1868. (Courtesy, National Park Service, Frederick Law Olmsted National Historic Site, Brookline, Massachusetts.)

thoroughly drained roads and walks follow gently curving lines. To enhance their attractiveness the designers suggested that the roadways be spacious and that thick plantings of trees and an abundance of turf embellish their borders. Olmsted and Vaux further advised that each house be placed at least thirty feet from the street, and that each owner plant one or two handsome trees between his house and the road. Such a plan, they predicted, would lend to the village "an aspect of secluded peacefulness and tranquility."³²

Along the primary drive through the village Olmsted and Vaux reserved a large tract of land, the long common, for public purposes, and at the center of town they designated a square for community facilities. On this latter site, adjacent to the railroad station, the Riverside Improvement Company erected a storage tower to distribute

fresh water to every home. Near the train depot the promoters also constructed a commercial block, which enabled residents to purchase needed goods without traveling to Chicago, and across the common from the business center they built William LeBaron Jenney's Riverside Hotel.³³

Olmsted and Vaux lent a sense of community to Riverside by placing throughout the suburb a series of small parks, areas possessing the "character of informal village-greens, commons and playgrounds." The main provision for public recreation, however, was a 160-acre park located along a three-mile stretch of the Des Plaines River as it meandered through the village. Near the river they arranged a drive and walk, and to enhance the park's attractiveness they recommended the construction of "pretty boat-landings, terraces, balconies overhanging the water, and pavilions at points desirable for observing regattas, mainly of rustic character, and to be half overgrown with vines."³⁴

The Riverside Improvement Company adopted the plans prepared by Olmsted, Vaux & Company, though not without lengthy debate. Unfortunately, the designers almost immediately encountered difficulties with the promoters. Childs defaulted on payments to the firm and, even worse, threatened to violate the unity of the plan by building his own house in the center of the most important public space, the long common. By October of 1869 a disgusted Olmsted termed the development a "regular fly away speculation," and Frederick C. Withers, Vaux's architectural partner, informed the designers that progress was so abysmal that the firm was losing potential business as a result. On April 30, 1870, Olmsted, Vaux & Company negotiated a release from their agreement with the Riverside promoters.³⁵

Riverside's woes were not over. The great Chicago fire of 1871 destroyed the company's records, and the economic panic of 1873 struck with such severity that the promoters defaulted on their obligations. Recovery was long delayed because capital previously available for suburban development instead was needed to finance the rebuilding of Chicago. But despite these difficulties, the village proprietors built upon the foundation Olmsted and Vaux established and Riverside eventually became the successful suburban community the designers had envisioned. Today, long since engulfed by the expanding city, Riverside's tree-lined curvilinear streets stand amidst a sprawling gridiron, but the community remains a bastion of domesticity and a monument to the nineteenth-century attempt to reconcile country and city.³⁶

The invention of the suburb in the nineteenth century, both in Europe and America, was part of the process of decentralization that fun-

damentally reshaped the urban environment. What once had been closely built areas—usually only three or four miles square—followed the extension of transportation lines and spread indiscriminately over the surrounding countryside. Decentralization reversed the traditional relationship of center and periphery, and those who could afford the cost often chose to move to suburban homes. Decentralization also demonstrated the importance of domesticity during the nineteenth century: "There is a fixed tendency among civilized men," Olmsted pointed out, "to place more and more value upon the cleanliness and purity of the condition of their domestic life." These conditions may have suffered in a gridiron city, but decentralization made possible an alternative to compact urban building and the creation of discrete residential neighborhoods more appropriate to domesticity.³⁷

Unfortunately, most suburban development in the nineteenth century was as unplanned as the linear expansion of the city. Too often it was undertaken with the expectation of reaping handsome profits, and, in the absence of a clearly defined public policy, those individuals who selected such locations for their homes and the contractors who built them collectively determined irrevocably the landscape of the modern city. Sam Bass Warner's investigation of urban growth in Boston, for example, demonstrates that the twentieth-century metropolis is the "product of hundreds of thousands of separate decisions."³⁸

Even so successfully designed a community as Riverside, which codified the suburban ideal and which served as a model for similar development in other cities, had drawbacks. The affluent who moved to the more congenial environment of the suburbs turned their backs on those whom Charles Loring Brace called the "dangerous classes," and, partly as a result, the city fragmented into a series of discrete residential neighborhoods divided by race, ethnic origins, and economic activities. This flight to the suburbs, at first a trickle but later an exodus, included individuals who were turning away from the city as physical form and from the complexity of new work and interpersonal relationships. In their quest for personal security and domestic bliss amid suburban surroundings, these people made personal decisions that had public implications, ignoring the effect they might have on broader social problems and the quality of urban life. To the supremacy of privatistic values Warner ascribes the breakdown of the city as community. Tragically, the nineteenth-century search for an urban compromise failed to bring about a new balance of country and city. To do so the suburb would have to be planned comprehensively, as an integral part of the modern metropolis rather than an escape from it.³⁹

CHAPTER IX

THE NEW CITY: A HOUSE WITH MANY ROOMS

The principle of a division of labor may, with advantage, be measurably applied to the plan of a city; one part of it being laid out with a view to the development of one class of utilities, another to a different class, according as natural circumstances favor.

— FREDERICK LAW OLMSTED and JOHN JAMES ROBERTSON CROES

Neither decentralization nor suburbanization was adequate to the task of refining and civilizing America's cities. To be sure, the move to a home on the urban periphery enabled those families that could afford it to escape urban congestion, but in relocating a distance from cities those individuals too often turned their backs on the persisting problems of urban life—tenements, filth, corruption, and disease. Nor, in the absence of comprehensive planning, did decentralization and suburbanization even have much of a positive impact on the spatial arrangement of cities. Most development on what Kenneth T. Jackson has called the "crabgrass frontier" was, like Dearman and Chicago's Hyde Park, really nothing more than linear extension of the urban gridiron. Instead of creating more openly built cities these communities increased the distance separating town and country. And, as Olmsted and Vaux learned at Riverside, not even the most imaginative plans and the best intentions were commensurate to the needs of the modern metropolis. The properly designed suburb was too costly, too likely to be victimized by changing economic conditions, and too ready a target for the designs of speculators and their "Gold Exchange and Erie [Railroad] principles" to be a panacea for the challenges confronting the nineteenth-century city.¹

Although at first decentralization was so unplanned that it compounded rather than solved the problem of urban congestion, Olmsted shrewdly recognized that modern transportation systems made possible the implementation of a new pattern of city form. In his estimation, streetcar and railway lines, together with parks and parkways, could bring about the "suburbanizing" of the residential sections of large towns and provide "elbow room about a house with-